MONEY MADE SIMPLE · GUIDE + SPREADSHEET

The Debt-Free Date Planner

Put a real date on the day you owe nothing. Up to ten debts, avalanche or snowball or your own order, and calculators that tell you if a balance transfer or consolidation loan would actually save money.

Setup in ~45 min | Up to 10 debts | Month-by-month plan | Call scripts



Edition 1.0

Educational content. Not financial advice.

START HERE

What's inside

Debt feels endless when it has no finish line. This planner gives it one: a month and a year, worked out from your real balances, rates and payments. Then it shows you how to pull that date closer.

1. List every debt (and find the numbers that matter) **3**

2. Pick your method: avalanche, snowball or custom **4**

3. Find your extra payment, and what it's worth **5**

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How to use the spreadsheet

Debt-Free-Date-Planner.xlsx opens in Excel, Google Sheets (File → Import → Upload) and Apple Numbers. Yellow cells are inputs; white cells calculate.

Tab	What it does
Plan	Your debts, your method and your extra payment. Shows the payoff month for every debt, your debt-free date, total interest, and how that compares with paying only the minimums.
Balance Transfer	Stay on your current card, or move the balance to a promo-rate card and pay the fee? It works out which costs less.
Consolidation	Compares one fixed-rate loan (with its fee) against your current plan.
Progress	Type your real total balance once a month and see if you're ahead of plan. Includes a chart of the plan.
Schedule	The month-by-month engine for up to 30 years. No inputs; look, don't touch.

PLEASE READ

This is general education and a planning tool, not financial, legal or tax advice. Interest is estimated monthly (APR ÷ 12); lenders calculate daily, so real numbers will differ a little. The example person and figures are fictional. If you're behind on payments, being contacted by collectors, or considering bankruptcy, talk to a non-profit credit counsellor (in the US, an NFCC member agency) or a lawyer before making big decisions.

STEP 1 · 20 MINUTES

List every debt

You need four numbers per debt. Log in to each account (or grab the latest statement) and copy them into the Plan tab.

NUMBER 1

Balance

What you owe today. For cards, the current balance, not the statement balance.

NUMBER 2

APR

The annual interest rate. On card statements it's in the "Interest charge calculation" box. Use the purchase APR.

NUMBER 3

Minimum

The minimum monthly payment. Card minimums shrink as the balance does; use today's.

NUMBER 4

Promo?

Any 0% or deferred-interest promo, and when it ends. Note it; you'll need it in Step 4.

What to include

- ✔ Credit cards and store cards
- ✔ Buy now, pay later plans
- ✔ Personal loans, car loans, student loans
- ✔ Medical payment plans, money owed to family (if there's a set payment)

Leave out your mortgage unless you specifically want to plan it here; its long term and low rate would push your debt-free date out decades and hide the progress on everything else.

Our example: Jordan (fictional)

Debt	Balance	APR	Minimum
Store card	$900	29.99%	$35
Credit card	$4,200	24.9%	$105
Personal loan	$1,800	11%	$75
Car loan	$6,500	7.9%	$210
Student loan	$14,000	5.5%	$180
Total	**$27,400**		**$605**

WATCH FOR RED

If a minimum cell turns red, that minimum doesn't even cover the monthly interest, so the balance can't shrink on minimums alone. That debt needs attention first: a lower rate (Step 4) or a bigger payment.

STEP 2 · 5 MINUTES

Pick your method

Every method has the same rule: pay the minimum on everything, then throw every extra dollar at one target debt. When it's gone, its payment rolls onto the next target. The methods only differ in the order.

AVALANCHE

Highest APR first

Costs the least interest. Best if you're motivated by the math and can wait a while for the first debt to disappear.

SNOWBALL

Smallest balance first

Costs a bit more interest, but you close accounts sooner. Best if quick wins keep you going.

CUSTOM

Your order

Type 1, 2, 3… in the "Custom order" column. Useful for a promo ending soon, or a debt to a person you'd like to clear first.

Jordan's plan, with $200 a month extra

Plan	Debt-free in	Total interest	First debt gone
Minimums only (no rollover)	97 months	$9,804	Personal loan, month 28
Avalanche	39 months	$3,804	Store card, month 5
Snowball	39 months	$3,985	Store card, month 5; personal loan month 10

For Jordan, avalanche saves about $181 over snowball, and both finish in the same month. Snowball clears the personal loan ten months sooner, so Jordan has one less bill to think about much earlier. Either plan saves around $6,000 compared with minimums only. **The method matters far less than having one and sticking to it.**

HOW TO CHOOSE IN TEN SECONDS

Have you started a debt plan before and given up? Choose **snowball**. Otherwise choose **avalanche**. You can switch any time; the spreadsheet recalculates instantly.

The rollover is the whole trick

When the store card is paid off in month 5, its $35 minimum doesn't go back into Jordan's spending. It joins the $200 extra and goes to the next target. By the last debt, Jordan is paying the original $605 + $200 = $805 a month into a single loan. The spreadsheet does this automatically, which is why the debt-free date falls so much faster than paying minimums.

STEP 3 · 15 MINUTES

Find your extra payment

The extra payment is the lever that moves your date. Here's what different amounts would do for Jordan (avalanche):

Extra per month	Debt-free in	Total interest	vs. $0 extra
$0 (minimums, but with rollover)	57 months	$7,071	—
$100	46 months	$4,836	$2,235 less
$200	**39 months**	**$3,804**	**$3,267 less**
$400	31 months	$2,777	$4,294 less

Notice two things. First, even with **no extra money**, rolling paid-off minimums forward (57 months) beats paying each debt separately (97 months). Second, the first $100 extra does the most work. Every extra dollar helps, so start with what you can, even if it's $25.

Where the extra comes from

- **Cut recurring charges.** Run a subscription and bill audit; most people find something. (The Bill Cut Kit walks through it in an hour.)
- **Give your spending a ceiling.** A weekly spending number with a firm limit makes the leftover visible, and the leftover can go to debt.
- **Lower your rates** (next page). A lower APR means more of the same payment goes to the balance.
- **Windfalls.** Tax refunds, bonuses, gifts, side income. A simple rule: half to debt, half to you.
- **Pause extra investing, not the match.** If you get an employer retirement match, keep contributing enough to get it. That match is usually worth more than paying down most debts faster.

BUILD A SMALL CUSHION FIRST

If you have no savings at all, the next car repair goes straight back on a card. Many people set aside a starter emergency fund (often $500 to $1,000) before putting extra money toward debt. Put it in a separate savings account so it isn't spent by accident.

STEP 4 · 30 MINUTES

Lower your rates

Three ways to pay less interest on the same debt. Try them in this order: the call costs nothing, the others have fees and need good-enough credit.

1. Ask (5 minutes per card)

Script: lower APR

"Hi, I've had this card for [X years] and I pay on time. I'm working on paying off the balance, and my APR of [X%] is making that hard. Is there any way you can lower it? I've had offers from other cards."

If no: "Is there a hardship program or a promotional rate available on my account?" Ask what conditions come with it before you agree (some freeze the card).

2. Balance transfer card

Moves a card balance to a new card with a low or 0% promo rate for a set time, usually for a fee (commonly 3% to 5% of the amount). The **Balance Transfer** tab compares the two paths. For a $3,000 balance at 24.9% paid at $200 a month, staying put costs about $631 in interest; a 15-month 0% transfer with a 3% fee costs about $92. It's only worth it if:

- the fee is less than the interest you'd save (the tab tells you),
- you can pay most or all of it off before the promo ends (the tab shows the monthly payment needed), and
- you stop using both cards for new spending. Moving debt and then refilling the old card is how people end up with twice the debt.

3. Consolidation loan

A fixed-rate personal loan that pays off several debts, leaving one payment with an end date. The **Consolidation** tab compares it with your current plan. It helps when the loan's APR (including fees) is well below your debts' average rate. In Jordan's example it doesn't: much of the debt is already at 5.5–7.9%, so a 12.5% loan with a 4% fee costs more. Run your own numbers before you apply.

FEDERAL STUDENT LOANS ARE DIFFERENT

They come with protections that private loans don't have, like income-driven repayment, deferment and forbearance. Refinancing or consolidating them into a private loan gives those up permanently. Federal repayment rules changed in 2025–2026, so check StudentAid.gov or your servicer for the options that apply to you now.

STEP 5 · 15 MINUTES, THEN 5 MINUTES A MONTH

Automate it, and stay with it

The plan only works if the payments happen every month without you having to be strong. Set it up once.

1. **Autopay the minimum on every debt.** A late payment costs a fee, can trigger a higher penalty rate, and hurts your credit. Autopay removes that risk.
2. **Schedule the extra payment for the day after payday,** as a recurring payment to your current target debt. Money that leaves first doesn't get spent.
3. **When a debt hits zero,** move that autopay amount to the next target the same day. This is the rollover; don't let it leak back into spending.
4. **Once a month (5 minutes):** add up your balances, type the total into the Progress tab, and colour in your tracker (page 9).

Staying motivated

- **Watch the date, not the balance.** Your debt-free date on the Plan tab is the number to celebrate. Every extra payment pulls it closer, and you can see it move.
- **Mark each payoff.** When a debt is gone, do something small and free (or cheap) to celebrate it, and tell someone.
- **Expect a bad month.** A slip isn't failure. Pay the minimums, skip the extra that month, and restart next payday. The plan recalculates.

Should I close cards as I pay them off?

Usually not right away. Closing a card removes its credit limit, which can raise your credit utilization, and closes an account that may be adding to your credit history. If a card has an annual fee or you can't trust yourself with it, it's reasonable to close it; otherwise many people keep it open with a tiny recurring charge on autopay. If the temptation is the problem, remove the card from your wallet and saved payment details.

When you're done

Keep paying the same total amount, to yourself: first to a full emergency fund (often 3 to 6 months of essential costs), then to investing. You're already used to living without that money, which makes it the easiest saving you'll ever do.

HONESTY PAGE

When the plan isn't enough

If the Plan tab says "30+ years", or the minimums alone are more than you can pay, a payoff plan by itself won't fix it. That's not a personal failure. It means you need a different tool, and there are good ones.

Signs it's time for outside help

- [ ] You're using credit cards to pay for essentials or other debts
- [ ] You've missed payments or a debt has gone to collections
- [ ] Minimum payments take more than you can afford after rent and food
- [ ] You're being sued, or wages are being garnished

Your options, from least to most drastic

Option	What it is	Watch out for
Hardship programs	Ask each lender. Temporary lower rate or payment.	Conditions like a frozen card; get terms in writing.
Non-profit credit counselling	A free or low-cost session to review your whole situation. Look for an NFCC member agency.	"Non-profit" in the name isn't proof; check accreditation.
Debt management plan	Arranged by a counselling agency: one monthly payment, often with reduced card rates, usually over 3 to 5 years.	Small monthly fee; cards are usually closed.
Debt settlement	A company negotiates to pay less than you owe, while you stop paying and save into an account.	Damages credit, fees, possible lawsuits, and forgiven debt may be taxable. Under FTC rules they can't charge fees before settling a debt.
Bankruptcy	A legal process that can discharge or restructure debts.	Serious, long-lasting credit impact. Get a consultation with a bankruptcy attorney; many offer a free first one.

RED FLAGS

Anyone who charges big upfront fees, guarantees to make debts disappear, tells you to stop talking to your creditors, or pressures you to sign today. Check complaints with the CFPB (consumerfinance.gov) and your state attorney general before you sign anything.

PRINT ME · STICK IT ON THE FRIDGE

Payoff tracker

Each square = 10% of that debt. Colour one in each time the balance drops another tenth. Debt-free date: _____

Debt	Start balance	Progress (one square = 10%)	Paid off on
		☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐☐	
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Total debt, month by month

Month	Total owed	Month	Total owed	Month	Total owed
1		9		17	
2		10		18	
3		11		19	
4		12		20	
5		13		21	
6		14		22	
7		15		23	
8		16		24	

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AFTER THE LAST PAYMENT

Turn your debt payment into an investment

The day your last debt is paid, you'll have a few hundred dollars a month you're already used to living without. That's the perfect start for investing.

Start Investing With $100 a Month walks you through it in plain English: which account to open first, what a 401(k) match is worth, Roth vs Traditional in one question, what to actually buy (index and target-date funds), fees, and how to automate it. It comes with growth, fee and match calculators.

NEXT STEP

Start Investing With $100 a Month

Guide + calculator spreadsheet.

$19

Debt Planner buyers: code **DEBTFREE5** for $5 off.

EVERYTHING

The Money Made Simple Toolkit

All five kits: Bill Cut, 20-Minute Budget, Credit Report Audit, this planner, and the investing kit.

$39

Saves $23 against buying them one by one.

Find both at [your store link]. Educational content only, not financial advice.